Deloitte.



# USI proposal writing guide

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# Introduction

Writers must know basic grammar rules to ensure clarity, consistency, and accuracy. Retaining the reader's interest is what characterizes good writing. Grammatical errors, redundant expressions, and convoluted sentences can distract people from the message.

In his essay Politics and English Language, George Orwell outlines six rules of writing that help communicate accurately. Though they are not absolutes, they remain valid even today.

- Never use a metaphor, simile, or other figures of speech that you are used to seeing in print.
- Never use a long word where a short one will do.
- Always cut out a word if it is possible to do so
- Never use the passive when you can use the active.
- Never use a foreign phrase, a scientific word, or a jargon word if you can think of an everyday English equivalent.
- Break any of these rules sooner than say anything outright barbarous.

The Deloitte Language and Style Guide remains the single source of truth. This document provides an overview of its key points, as well as grammar tips to keep in mind when working on your proposals.

# Cover letters

The cover letter is the client's first impression of your proposal. It's a great opportunity to create an immediate connection. Here are some tips that can help you craft a one-of-a-kind cover letter:

- Keep cover letters to no more than a page.
- Personalize the note from the signing PPMD, when possible.
- It's okay to paraphrase key themes but do not duplicate the messaging in the executive summary.
- Avoid starting the cover letter by thanking the client in the first sentence.
- The first line should grab the reader's attention. A sentence like "we are grateful for the opportunity" is not a powerful opening.
- Maintain a conversational tone.
- Tailor the content to the client.
- Avoid jargon and use everyday language. For example, instead of "utilize" or "leverage," say "use."

Roy Sakelson, A&A pursuits senior manager, shares key points you should hit to pique the reader's attention. "Talk about something that resonated with you during a client conversation. For example: When we met last week to discuss your audit needs, you discussed the importance of trust. Without it, a relationship can't grow. I couldn't agree more. My team and I commit to earning your trust every single day. Whether it's making sure you always have a seat at the table during a technical consultation, giving you access to real-time status updates to the audit, or just returning your phone calls promptly."

Here's another great example of creating a connection and capturing attention early in the proposal. "An empowering vision can drive meaningful impact. 'Travel. Transformed.' is just that. As your lead client service partner over the past few years, it's been my privilege to witness you reimagining the customers' experience."

In both examples, the opening sentence focuses on the client and shows that we listened and they matter to us. Writers should strive to expand the value proposition and show the client the vision of the promised land. Simplify your idea and reinforce how the client can benefit from our services.

# Why it’s better to write in active voice

The first and foremost rule of writing is to use direct, clear, concise sentences. Hence, use active voice when possible. Brevity makes your writing more straightforward and action-focused, helping us tell stories more effectively. In an active voice, the subject performs the action.

For instance:

Example 1

- Passive Voice: The smaller statutory audits will be performed by a dedicated team of compliance specialists from the US Delivery Center.
- Active voice: A dedicated team of compliance specialists from the US Delivery Center will perform the smaller statutory audits.

The second example asserts that the subject, i.e., a team of compliance specialists, is performing the action. While in passive voice, the object is positioned first.

Example 2

- Passive voice: The tone at the top will be set by Jason, one of the most seasoned and respected leaders in our practice.
- Active Voice: Jason, one of our most seasoned and respected leaders, will set the tone at the top.

You will notice that the second is shorter and easier to understand. Always remember that less is more. When you write in an active voice, it makes your tone conversational and informal. In daily life, do any of us ever use the passive voice?

# Verb tense consistency

It's important to keep the same tense throughout the proposal. If your line lacks tense verb consistency, readers get confused about when the action is happening and distracted by the change in tense. Tense consistency sets a clear timeline, enhances your writing flow, and adds clarity.

The below example illustrates inconsistent verb tenses and shows how to rectify them.

- Inconsistent verb tense: You can expect our team to regularly walk the halls with you or assisting you remotely, share leading practices, and discussing ways to reduce the burden on your team.

- Consistent verb tense: You can expect our team to regularly walk the halls with you or assist you remotely, share leading practices, and discuss ways to reduce your team's burden.

In the first sentence, walk the halls is in the simple present tense, but assisting and discussing ways are in the present continuous tense. You will note that having multiple tenses in one line removes the focus from the main point. The second example demonstrates how consistent verb tenses can logically organize your train of thought.

# Bulleted lists

Using bullet points is an excellent way to structure your writing, highlight the main points, and break the text down. You must ensure that the bulleted lists are written with a parallel structure, as it's essential to maintain consistency. Writing grammatically consistent bullet points makes it easier to read and understand. Make sure all your points are in complete sentences or all fragments; avoid a mix of both.

### Consistency is key:

- Either all bullets in the section should be written in a sentence fragment format, or they should all be full sentences (ending in a period). For example:
    - Actionable insights and advice from ABC, who specializes in DEF
    - You will get actionable insights from ABC, who specializes in DEF.
- Be mindful of verb tense consistency; these errors turn up generally in team bios. For example:

  Experience
    - Serves as the national leader for GASB training…
    - Leads the technical consultation for…
    - ~~ABC has extensive experience in…~~

### How to punctuate

There are only three rules of punctuation in a bulleted list:

- Do not use punctuation at the end if it's a sentence fragment.
- Use a period after every bullet that is a full sentence.
- Consistency is key.

# Subject-verb agreement

Subject-verb agreement is an essential grammatical rule that makes the text easier to understand. In a sentence, you must use the correct verb form that matches the number, person, and gender of that person.

Let's take a look at some of the most common subject-verb agreement rules with examples:

A. With a plural subject, you must use the plural form of your verb. For example:

- **Incorrect:** The results of our analysis across the months is significant.
- **Correct:** The results of our analysis across the months are significant.

B. For a singular subject, use a singular verb. For example:

- **Incorrect:** ABC drive the technical consultation process.
- **Correct:** ABC drives the technical consultation process.

C. If two or more nouns or pronouns are connected using "and," then you must use the plural verb form. For example:

- **Incorrect:** John and Sara is planning a training session.
- **Correct:** John and Sara are planning a training session.

D. If a sentence contains singular and plural pronouns, then the verb used will be according to the pronoun closer to the verb. For example:

- **Incorrect:** Annabel and her friends is going for a meeting.
- **Correct:** Annabel and her friends are going for a meeting.

The first rule in making your subjects and verbs agree is that the subject must match the verb. If you remember this simple rule, spotting and avoiding subject-verb agreement errors will be easy.

# Capitalization

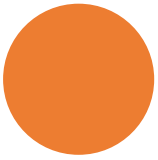
Capitalization should be reserved for proper names (Center for Banking Solutions) and formal names of companies' departments and businesses (Analytic & Forensic Technology).

1. Capitalize concepts, ideas, and issues only if they are recognized as proper names.
   For example:
   - Correct: Deloitte professionals are guided by the network's Purpose and Shared Values. (Capitalized because they're recognized as proper names at Deloitte.)
   - Incorrect: He talked about his company's Mission and Vision.

2. Do not capitalize industry and sector names, including the word industry (use ampersands only if this is the official name of the industry group). Lowercase industries and sectors and avoid ampersands in generic references. See examples below:
   - He recently became leader of Deloitte's global life sciences & health care practice The technology, media and entertainment, and telecommunications ecosystem remains as fascinating as ever.
   - Our mining & metals sector professionals have a comprehensive grasp of the silver mining industry.

   [Note: Rule #2 is verbatim from page 14 of the Deloitte Language and Style Guide.]

3. For proposal titles of engagement team members, use the following guidance:
   - Use lowercase when used as part of a sentence (of course, the first word is capitalized at the beginning of a sentence).
   - Use title case (initial letter caps) when added as a standalone title with the name, for example, as part of organization charts, quotes, or tables with details, or when the title is added ahead of the name.
   - Examples: 'The project will be led by your senior manager and…', 'The project will be led by your Senior Manager ABC and…', 'Lead client service partners are allowed to…".

   ABC ABC
   Tax Managing Director

   [Note: Rule #3 is a simplified version from page 14 of the Deloitte Language and Style Guide.]

4. Other guidance on capitalization:
    - Our service offerings are written in lowercase: audit committee, company, board, audit and assurance, consulting, financial advisory, risk advisory, and tax services.
    - Don't capitalize generic words such as practice, team, group, and department (marketing department, HR group, tax practice).
    - On the second reference: Capitalize the full names of agencies, associations, and committees on the first reference, but lowercase the generic term on the second reference (US Department of Labor, the department; National Mentoring Committee, the committee).
    - Capitalize the names of communications vehicles and specific groups. Do not capitalize the stand-alone names of services. For example: "The Southeast Asia Transaction Services group showed a video about its transaction services."

# Words to avoid

Writers should avoid certain words and phrases due to their risk or legal implications. Use absolute statements that can be substantiated. For example: "Deloitte is the world's largest professional services provider, by revenue and headcount." Never use absolute statements that cannot be substantiated. For example, avoid statements such as:

> "Deloitte will deliver the best audit services." Instead, say, "Deloitte will deliver high-quality audit services."
>
> "Deloitte has the best team in the profession." Instead, write, "Deloitte has one of the best teams in the profession."

The Audit Pursuit Quality Guidelines document contains the full list of words and phrases that may be problematic from a risk or legal perspective. Here's a list of some words you cannot use and their suggested alternatives.

| Word to avoid | Reason to not use | Alternatives |
|---|---|---|
| Assurances<br>Assure<br>Assured<br>Assuring | The use of this word could be considered as an absolute commitment or unintended guarantee by the legal entity (or entities) providing service to a higher standard of service. | corroborate, suggest, confirm, endeavor, work diligently toward, take reasonable steps |
| Ensure<br>Ensured<br>Ensuring | The use of this word could be considered as an absolute commitment or unintended guarantee by the legal entity (or entities) providing service to a higher standard of service. | intend, determine, confirm, endeavor, work diligently toward, take reasonable steps |
| Expert<br>Expertise | The use of this word could imply superior knowledge or a performance standard that cannot be defended by the legal entity (or entities) providing service because it is not attainable or measurable. | skilled, practiced, knowledgeable, proficient, practitioner, consultant, experienced |

You can use TERMinator, add-in to Word and PowerPoint to find and fix commonly used terms and phrases that may be inadvisable in business communications.

# Numbers

- Spell out (i.e., in words) numbers one through nine; use numerals for 10 and greater, even when there are mixed uses (for example seven and 17 in the same sentence).

  Exceptions:

  - Use numbers for addresses, dates, currency values, percentages, page numbers.
  - When starting a sentence with a number, spell it out. For example: Twenty-nine years of experience serving large public and multinational companies in several industries.

- Use the abbreviation 'No.' for 'number' with a figure to indicate position or rank. For example, 'Deloitte is ranked No. 1 among the Big Four in revenue.'
- Ordinals:
  - Numbers used to indicate order (first, second, 10th, 25th, etc.) are called ordinal numbers.
  - The same guidelines apply; spell out first through ninth: fourth year, first audit. Use figures starting from the 10th. Exception:
    - In headlines or infographics, figures may be used instead of first through ninth if space is an issue. For example, 'Mexico ranks 7th in the global survey.'
  - Do not superscript ordinals: 14th, not 14~~th~~.
  - Do not use ordinals in dates: May 14, 2023, not May 14~~th~~, 2023.
- Hyphen in spelled out numbers:
  - When used as an adjective, add a hyphen. For example, I walked for two hours and, 'I did a two-hour walk' is used as an adjective. We can add an 's' to a noun, but not to an adjective.

[Note: This is a simplified version from page 40 of the Deloitte Language and Style Guide.]

# Punctuation and miscellaneous guidance

- Deloitte US firm vs. individual entities: One of the common mistakes made is not defining whether a statistic is referring to the entity that will serve the client, or to all US entities. For example, the following statistic refers to Deloitte LLP and its US subsidiaries.
    - Multidisciplinary services provided to 90% in consumer product industry clients (*Fortune*, 2022).

  Recommended practice is to define 'Deloitte LLP and its US subsidiaries' as 'Deloitte US' in the first mention of cross-functional services/capability and using Deloitte US thereafter as appropriate (for example, a superscript [1] can define the entity in the notes at the bottom of the table).
- United States: When used as a noun, always spell out the United States and abbreviate when used as an adjective. Do not use periods with US, i.e., do not write U.S. or USA. For example, our 'US professionals' or 'specialists in the United States' is acceptable.
- Italics: Italics are used sparingly to emphasize certain words (key word here is 'sparingly'). Also, italicize titles of publications. For example, only the title is italicized, while quoting Fortune 500 ranking for qualifications.
    - Source: Internal analysis of Fortune 500 (*Fortune*, 2022).
- Parentheses: Avoid the use of parentheses. In our editors' opinion, if it's important enough to be in your writing, it's important enough to stand on its own. It shouldn't seem as if you are whispering something to the client.
- Em Dash: Minimize the use of an em dash (—); especially multiple instances on the same page. The em dash is a punctuation mark used in place of a comma, colon, semicolon, or parentheses to draw the reader's attention to explain or expand something that precedes it. For example:
    - We are already on the ground—leveraging the institutional knowledge of ABC company.
    - Delivering excellence—then, now, and onward.
    - However, the em dash is not preferred in formal writing, and it is best to use it sparingly.

  Do not confuse em dash with en dash (–). The en dash is used to indicate a range between two terms. It often replaces the word 'to.' For instance: The operations will be closed from August 1–August 31.
- Acronyms: Define the acronym in the first instance of its usage in the document. However, if the proper name is used only once in the document, no acronym is needed. While defining a client's name in the beginning, do not use quotation marks in the parentheses. For example: It is inspiring to see the impact that Amazing University of Texas (AUT) has…

- The usage of I and me is a tricky one. 'I' is a nominative pronoun, i.e., it is used as the subject of a sentence, and 'me' is an object pronoun, which means that it serves as a direct or indirect object to the verb or as the object of a preposition. A way to check is to remove the other people at the beginning and re-read the sentence to see if it sounds right. Simply put, use 'ABC and I' when you want to say 'we', and use 'ABC and I' when you want to say 'us.'
    - For example: My team and I will deliver high-quality audit services. In this sentence, there are two subjects,' My team and I.' We cannot use 'me' which is the objective case. As it's a subject, the correct pronoun is 'I.' If you remove my team, it reads as 'I will deliver high-quality audit services,' which is correct.

- Shall, should, will, and would are auxiliary verbs used with a main verb.
    - Shall is used to suggest something or express intention, as well as communicate obligations in the case of laws and directives. It can also be used to ask questions. For example:
        a. I shall go to the US to attend a conference.
        b. Shall we start the training session?
    - Should indicate a preference or idea. It is used to give advice or instructions. For example:
        a. You should be more open to ideas.
        b. We should arrive on time for the session.
    - Will refers to an action/event that will happen in the future. It can be used to make promises and offers or insist on something. For example:
        a. We will go above and beyond to deliver client service excellence.
        b. I will be late for the meeting.
    - 'Would' is used to describe past situations or beliefs. It can also be employed to politely request or describe a hypothetical situation. For example:
        a. She would work late at night to finish the project.
        b. Would you assist me in the XYZ project?

- Quotation marks:
    - Do not use double quotation marks to emphasize words. It typically means that the word has an opposite meaning. For example, the following sentence means the opposite. ABC will be your "trusted" adviser.
    - Periods and commas always go inside quotation marks.
    - Colons, semicolons, exclamation point, and question marks go outside the quotation marks, unless they are part of the quoted content.

- Avoid widows, i.e., single words that appear at the beginning or end of a paragraph, with the rest of the sentence on the previous or next page or column. For example:

    > Deloitte Omnia's Connect capability is a secure, global request and collaboration portal, enabling enhanced coordination and communication between the Deloitte team and client. With drill-down status dashboards and system-generated email alerts, Omnia Connect streamlines information requests. It provides greater visibility to status, leading to a transparent experience and a seamless exchange of information.

    A single word on the new line of a paragraph looks unbalanced and can be disruptive to the readers.

- Team members' bios:
    - Round up years instead of using 'more than'. For example, instead of 'more than eighteen years of experience in…', use '18 years of experience in…'
    - In the representative clients' list, consider starting with the names of companies that will be relevant to the reader. Also, if there is any instance where one of the company names has a comma included, all companies listed must be separated by a semicolon. For example: Representative clients: Mckesson; Walgreens; cities of Austin, Dallas, and Chicago; Draken.
    - Do not use LLP, Inc., Co. or similar in client lists unless an integral part of the company name.
        - Correct: The Dow Chemical Company
        - Incorrect: Meta Platforms Inc.

- Commas:
    - Commas with adjectives
        - Guiding principle: Use a comma only to separate two adjectives if the meaning remains the same when you swap the order of the adjectives or replace the comma with 'and'.
        - Use a comma for coordinate adjectives. These describe the same noun equally, and by swapping their order or adding an 'and' in between, the meaning does not change. For example, 'risk-based, efficient audit', or 'efficient, risk-based audit' or 'efficient and risk-based audit mean the same.

    - Do not use a comma for cumulative adjectives. Unlike coordinate adjectives, these build upon each other. For example, 'one integrated innovation platform'. There will be no comma in this case. We can not replace this by saying '~~integrated one~~ innovation platform'.
    - Limit the number of adjectives used. Here's an example of what to avoid: our first-class public company financial services practice

- Oxford/serial comma: The use of Oxford/serial commas, the one that comes before 'and' or 'or,' is preferred when the sentence is longer and more complex. It would enhance the clarity. For example: Our integrated innovation platform supports the entire audit process to achieve greater effectiveness and efficiency, reduce your burden, and deliver valuable insights.

# American English vs. British English

This section will highlight some significant differences between American and British forms of English. American English generally uses ‘or,’ and British English uses ‘our.’

| British | American |
|---|---|
| Colour | Color |
| Candour | Candor |
| Honour | Honor |
| Endeavour | Endeavor |
| Honour | Honor |
| Labour | Labor |

In American English, some nouns end with ‘ense’ and ‘ence’ in British English.

| British | American |
|---|---|
| Defence | Defense |
| Licence | License |
| Offence | Offense |
| Pretence | Pretense |

Many words in American English are spelled as ‘er’ and ‘re’ in British English.

| British | American |
|---|---|
| Calibre | Caliber |
| Metre | Meter |
| Centre | Center |
| Manoeuvre | Maneuver |

Verbs in American English are spelled as ‘yze’ and ‘yse’ in British English.

| British | American |
|---|---|
| Analyse | Analyze |
| Catalyse | Catalyze |
| Paralyse | Paralyze |

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